

Mexican envoy tumbled into creek

by Barbara Shenstone
Gazette editor

The organizers had always said the opening ceremonies of Almonte's centennial would be like nothing else the town had ever seen.

And so they were, albeit the site of a dripping, mud smeared Mexican ambassador scrambling out of a water logged culvert in Gemmill Park was hardly on the carefully prepared agenda.

Since nobody was seriously hurt, the upsetting of the horse drawn carriage that was taking His Excellency Augustin Barrios Gomez, his wife, and Mr and Mrs John Dunn in a stately cavalcade to Gemmill Park, will go down in history as comedy.

As the mayor himself said when it was all over, and the dignitaries had changed into dry clothes, and made their entrance at last on the outdoor stage set up in the bowl below the arena.

"We have invited foreign guests to Almonte before," said Pettim, "but not usually for a swim."

The light remark came when order had been restored and it was evident that no one had been seriously injured. But the sober face of the mayor and everyone else involved, showed that everyone was thanking the heavens the accident had not ended in tragedy.

The Almonte Centennial Committee had always wanted to make these celebrations something extra special. The invitation of the Mexican am-

bassador seemed a fitting way to remember the curious quirk of fate that saw the town named over a hundred years ago after the famous Mexican General Almonte.

His excellency was the cornerstone of the opening celebrations, and the centennial committee did itself proud in arranging the little cavalcade that took him by buggy through the streets of Almonte before making its way, with pipe and drum, up the Bay Hill to Gemmill Park.

Until that moment, everything had run smoothly. His excellency, accompanied by his wife, brother-in-law and ten-year-old son, were greeted warmly by the committee when they arrived by limousine at the house of Mr Gerry Wheatley.

After light refreshments, the party proceeded to the front of the townhall, just across the bridge from Mr Wheatley's house, to take part in the official welcome by the mayor and town council.

After due ceremony, the ambassador and Mrs Barrios Gomez climbed into the graceful landau, and along with Mr and Mrs John Dunn, prepared to make their way in state along Bridge Street and down Mill Street.

Mr Robert McEnaghan, of Perth, drove the carriage from his high seat at the front of the vehicle. By his side sat Ken Camelon, a former resident of Almonte, now acting as "ceremonial groom". Both men, in tails and white starch shirts, wore high top hats in the customary style of 100 years ago.

A killed piped led the cavalcade of buggy, and limousine carrying the other members of Ambassador Barrios Gomez family. A police car cleared the traffic before them. Children, tourists, and press photographers, walk along beside the slow moving procession.

Meanwhile in Gemmill Park, the final arrangements were being made for the official opening ceremonies.

The Centennial Choir, led by Mrs Thora Pugh, was warming by the outdoor stage set up behind the arena. The band of the Governor-General's Footguard had already played several introductory numbers, as the crowd began to collect on the side of the hill that formed the natural outdoor theatre.

The Ambassador's cavalcade entered the park from Bay Hill, and it was evidently when the horse reached the top of the incline and saw the crowd, that the accident happened.

According to the driver, the horse paused on the steep slope at the sight of the crowd. It did not shy, but when the carriage lost momentum, the horse jerked forward again.

The strain caused the wattle tree, a piece of the harness, to snap. The horse got clear, but the landau slipped sideways over the edge of a culvert, turning over as it fell about four feet into a ditch below.

The passengers in the carriage were tossed along with the vehicle into the ditch, which had about a foot of water in it.

The buggy, which is very light, in fact momentarily pinned Mrs Gomez under one side. Mr Gerry Wheatley, who left out of the limousine he was riding in behind the buggy, was able to quickly lift the vehicle out of her way.

Mrs Gomez was soaked but escaped injury other than a scrape on her head.

Mr Gomez suffered a few bumps and bruises too, as did Mrs Dunn. Mr Dunn sprained his wrist.

Robert McEnaghan, the driver, who had had back trouble before, had to stretch out on the grass after the tumble, when his back seized up again.

Dr Murphy attended to him, he was later checked at the Almonte hospital. A little girl, who was walking up the hill beside the carriage, is also thought to have been slightly injured when he skidding vehicle brushed past her.

She ran off home before anyone could identify her.

After the initial commotion, the carriage party returned to Mr Wheatley's house to dry themselves off.

Almonte Councillor Paul Finner lent the Ambassador a clean suit, and apart from the rather sober atmosphere that prevailed among them for the rest of the afternoon, there was no sign, when the officials reappeared in Gemmill Park an hour later, that anything so unfortunate had happened.

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Otherwise, all goes well

In spite of the upset of the Mexican ambassador Saturday, the festivities marking Almonte's cen-

tenial have been running smoothly this week, drawing large crowds to most activities.

The festival began Thursday with a Monster Bingo Night sponsored by the Almonte Civic Club. The attendance of about 400 was a bit low compared to other years, but organizers were happy with the turn-out on the first event on the week.

The bingo featured many cash prizes, and a \$500 bonus prize, which was won by Mrs Nora Vaughan.

Friday saw a good crowd at the North Lanark Agricultural Society's horse draw at the fairgrounds.

There was good competition in light and heavy classes, although the names of winners were not available at press time.

The popular Irish band, Jug O' Punch, drew a crowd estimated at about 730 to the arena later Friday night. There was a great deal of dancing and singing, and with the help of the refreshment tables manned by employees of Bruce Instruments.

The fun began in earnest Saturday, with a softball and tennis tournament and a fishing derby. Hot sunny weather brought people out in droves and an estimated 1500 people watched the official opening ceremony at Gemmill Park Saturday afternoon.

The musical entertainment for the occasion was excellent, and carried the event over the momentary delay caused by the overturning of the buggy carrying the Mexican ambassador and his wife to the opening ceremonies.

The Centennial Choir, led by Mrs Thora Pugh, "played on", as the expression goes, until the party of dignitaries could regroup. They gave a fine concert and will sing again in a concert all their own on Thursday.

The band of the Governor-General's Footguard alternated with the choir in providing the afternoon's musical entertainment. They too showed their mettle in the brief contest, and played several specially chosen Mexican numbers for His Excellency.

One of the highlights of the afternoon was the skydiving display put on by an area skydiving club, Ottawa Sports Parachutists Inc.

From 5000 feet, 12 jumpers fell in two groups, joining hands and then spreading out before opening their wide rectangular chutes. Some made patterns in the sky above the park with red smoke flairs before dropping with

perfect precision on the target at the centre of the park's football field.

The jumpers, (four were women), were led by veteran jumper, Horst Plans, a teacher at Almonte High School.

Plans has made over 1500 jumps, is a master jumper, and has been an instructor for the armed forces.

When the official opening took place after the skydiving, John Dunn, chairman of the centennial committee, introduced Mexican ambassador Augustin Barrios Gomez, his wife, Patricia, and other dignitaries, including Almonte mayor Ron Pettim, and Mrs Pettim, and MPP Doug Wemyss, and Mrs Wemyss.

Mrs Ruth Marshall later officially presented mayor Pettim with an quilted and embroidered banner depicting the town crest on a turquoise background with the town's motto, "Never a backward step". Mrs Marshall had made the banner herself as a centennial project.

Ambassador Barrios Gomez courteously wished Almonte a happy anniversary, and referred to it as the "amigo country". He pointed out that his wife, a sculptor, had had an earlier connection with Almonte. Her work, as cast by artist Dale Dunning, whose foundry is located near the eighth line of Ramsay township, near Almonte.

The carving of the enormous birthday cake rounded out the afternoon. The cake, which fed hundreds of people, was made by the Richmond Bakery.

The Grand Centennial Ball was the event of Saturday evening. A 16-piece band led the dancers, many dressed in costume of the last hundred years, during what several called one of the best entertainments of the season.

Centennial activities continued Sunday with special church services and in the afternoon a pop concert by the Glebe Stage Band in Gemmill Park.

The Wesleyan Methodist cemetery was rededicated in an official ceremony the same afternoon.

The Tarent's pancake breakfast drew a crowd that lined up across the Front Bridge on Monday morning. It was the largest this annual event has ever seen.

An antique steam and car show and a children's soap box derby were other highlights of the day.

Centennial activities for children and adults continue throughout the week. Check ads in this paper for details.



The visiting ambassador of Mexico, Augustin Barrios Gomez, climbs out of the ditch with the help of John Dunn, chairman of the Almonte Centennial Committee. Six people were thrown into the muddy water of

a hole in Gemmill Park when the carriage the ambassador was riding in overturned just before the opening ceremonies of Homecoming Week. Fortunately no one was seriously hurt.

School may become animal shelter

by Susan Fisher
Gazette reporter

The Lanark County branch of the Ontario Humane Society (OHS) has decided to submit an offer to purchase an old school in Smith's Falls with the idea of renovating it for a much needed animal shelter.

The Harper Condie School, which was sold by the Lanark County Board of Education several years ago, has about 10,000 square feet of space and contains eight classrooms.

Gary Thibron, president of the Lanark County branch of the OHS, estimates renovating the school rather

than building a new shelter, could save more than \$40,000.

Thibron expects the purchase price plus renovations would be less than \$90,000, whereas original estimates for building and equipping a shelter were about \$135,000.

The move to buy the Harper Condie school has been approved by executive director of the OHS, Tom Hughes.

The offer to purchase depends on the outcome of a rezoning request made to the Montague Township planning board. According to Mr Thibron, the request comes before the board on August 18.

See major renovation. "It is necessary if the Humane Society did take over the Harper Condie school, and some equipment would have to be installed, but according to Thibron, that would be about the extent of renovation.

Thibron feels the location of the school would be more accessible than the site of the shelter the Humane Society had planned to build about three miles from the highway near Franktown.

To date, the society has found it an uphill struggle to raise funds for a

shelter. However, according to Mr Thibron, the society has more than \$30,000 in the bank. He also plans to continue its fight for provincial government funding.

For some time now, to make shift "shelter" for the Lanark County area has been operating from the home of Mr Dawn Trent in Lanark.

Thibron pointed out, "It's not a shelter really, and we shouldn't be calling it that. It gives people the idea that we have perfectly adequate facilities already, and why do we want money for a new one?"

Thibron went on to explain that the present facilities are private kennels owned by Mrs Dawn Trent. "It began when the wind blew Mrs Trent's solo over. Once she had recovered the insurance money for damages, instead of building a new site, she built these kennels to be used temporarily for the Lanark County Humane Society."

Thibron added Mrs Trent can house about 15 dogs on her property, as well as some cats in another portion of the barn.

"We also spend quite a lot of money in boarding fees with veterinarian clinics in Lanark County," said Thibron.

The Harper Condie school, which the Humane Society is hoping to purchase, was listed for \$54,900 on the open market. According to Thibron, the Humane Society's offer was not much less than the listed price.

Wayne Irwin and Mr and Mrs Roland Deibel.

Each member and the judge received a silver centennial spoon donated by the Almonte Lions Club.

The entertainment for the evening was a 16-piece orchestra which was named the Almonte Centennial Orchestra. The band leader, Gordon Rushworth, had picked the orchestra from musicians in Ottawa.

When the orchestra took breaks the entertainment continued with a group of three who played country music.

The group consisted of Floyd Brunton and Gerry Mechan, who played fiddles and David Gordwood who played the piano.

Dancing down the century

by Allison Paul
Gazette reporter

The theme of dancing through the centuries was well displayed both through costume and music, last Saturday at the Centennial Grand Ball.

Mistake

A story in last week's Gazette incorrectly identified a story with a headline that read "Assault."

The headline had no connection with the story over which it appeared, and in fact referred to another incident entirely.

The Gazette apologizes for any misunderstanding caused by this error.

Many of the crowd of about 400 who attended the ball came in costume of all different periods, ranging from 100 years ago through the flapper craze to present.

Near the end of the ball everyone in costume paraded around the dance floor while the four judges selected winners of an informal costume contest.

The judges were Mayor Ron Pettim and his wife and chairman of the centennial committee, John Dunn, and his wife.

The costumes were judged in couples, whenever the same time period. The four winners were Steve Sweeney and Andrew Powers, Mr and Mrs Brian Gallagher, Mr and Mrs

Firm leading field in electronics

by Allison Paul
Gazette reporter

Bruce Instruments Ltd, of Almonte, has received a \$200,000 loan from the Eastern Ontario Development Corporation to buy new equipment.

The company has already bought a lot of the equipment, such as a new soldering machine and engineering lab equipment.

The two-year-old company is the only company in Canada which manufactures wireless remote control converters.

The only competitor the company has is in the United States.

Currently Bruce Instruments are making about 200 converters a day but they are trying to get up to 500 to 1,000 a day.

Bruce Hempell, vice president of engineering, and founder of the company said by the beginning of next year they will be exporting into the United States.

When this happens the company could be making about 1,000 to 2,000 units a day by sub-contracting.

When the volume gets big we will have to go to automatic assembly, Hempell said.

The difference between the Canadian and American markets is that in Canada it is a consumer market and in the States it is the cable companies that supply the converters.

The converter retail for \$169.95 and a couple of its unique features is that it has a recall button and a tuning button.

Currently there are 50 employees at Bruce Instruments but they could expand to as many as 200, he said. "I really don't want to get too big here," Hempell said.

Ronald McDonald

The Almonte Civic Club has made arrangements to have Ronald McDonald in attendance at the Centennial parade.

Ronald will ride on the Almonte Civic Club float and will pass out treats to the children along the parade route.

Anyone wishing to meet him can do so at the conclusion of the parade beside the arena.